

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ J 3

♥ J 9 5 2

♦ K 6 5

♣ A 8 5 2

♠ K 9 7 2

♥ 6

♦ 7 4 3

♣ Q 10 7 4 3



♠ Q 6 4

♥ A 10 8 3

♦ 10 9 8 2

♣ 9 6

♠ A 10 8 5

♥ K Q 7 4

♦ A Q J

♣ K J

West	North	East	South
			2NT

Pass	3♣	Pass	3♥
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Pass	3NT	Pass	4♠
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All Pass

4♠ by South

a chance of working. Let's say a 50% chance. Do you take it?

No, of course not. Not when you have a play that offers almost a 100% chance. Win the ♦A, play ♠K, ♠A, then ♥K Q, discarding dummy's 2 ♦ losers.

With one master trump still out you start on the ♣s, playing first the ♣K, then overtake the ♣J with dummy's ♣Q. The defense is welcome to take their ♣A whenever they want, and they are also welcome to their trump trick. You are so gracious because you have your ten tricks!

Half the time the ♦K will be with East, and the inferior plan of taking the finesse will work. On those Deals your superior plan shows no payoff.

But the other 50% of the time West will have the ♦K. On those Deals you get your just reward.

When you have 4 cards in both Majors you respond 2♥ to a Stayman request. Partner now bids 3NT.

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Partner denies having 4♥s so he must have 4♠s (or he would not have used Stayman). You correct the contract to 4♠.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♥2. East grabs the opening lead with the ♥A and plays the ♦10.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

The ♠, ♥ and ♣ losers are inevitable so you'd better not lose a ♦. Even though East has returned a ♦ it is still possible that he holds the ♦K so the finesse has

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 8

♥ J 7 3 2

♦ K 9 7 4

♣ K

♠ 7 3

♥ 6 5

♦ J 2

♣ A J 9 8 7 4 3

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W		E
	S	

♠ 9 6 4 2

♥ K Q 10

♦ Q 10 5

♣ 10 6 2

♠ A K 5

♥ A 9 8 4

♦ A 8 6 3

♣ Q 5

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			

You do have 9 points, of a sort anyway. Hoping your ♣ suit will be of use, you invite with 2NT. Partner says 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠Q, East following with the ♠2. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

No, don't hold up. At least you have ♠s stopped twice, your other suits are stopped only once.

Realizing that your only hope is for a bunch of ♣ tricks you win the ♠K and play the ♣Q. West covers with the ♣K. What do you do?

If you win with dummy's ♣A, and if the ♣s split 2-2, you can win 7 ♣ tricks and 4 other high cards. Wow!

But if it turns out that the ♣K was singleton you will win just TWO ♣ tricks because dummy has no other entries.

So if you feel like gambling, go up with the ♣A. But if you like the idea of a guaranteed contract let West hold the ♣K, and you make sure of the six other ♣s.

This Deal is not a "made up" one, it was actually played at our Monday Duplicate game in May 2012.

The play went exactly as shown above. When her LHO played the ♣K our declarer ducked in dummy and made the contract.

Board 5

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q
 ♥ Q 9 8 6 2
 ♦ 9 5
 ♣ K Q J 9 3

♠ A 10 4 3

♥ 7 3

♦ K Q 8 7 4 2

♣ 7



♠ K J 9 6
 ♥ J 10 5 4
 ♦ 10 6
 ♣ 10 8 5

♠ 8 7 5 2

♥ A K

♦ A J 3

♣ A 6 4 2

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by South

Missing 5 ♠s, the most likely split is 3-2, (68% of the time). You win the ♣A and play a small ♠ toward dummy. West puts on the ♠Q which you take with dummy's ♠A, East following with the ♠6.

Do you play ♠s again? or not?

Not. With both defenders following suit, the possibility of 4 ♠ losers is gone so you can lose at most 3. But that ♠Q from West is ominous. If you play another ♠ and they do split 3-2 you will make 11 tricks, losing only 2 trumps. But if East has 3 ♠s left he will win the trick, pull all the rest of the trumps, and lead a ♣ to West.

The guaranteed way to make the contract is to play no more ♠s, but to start playing ♦ winners. The defenders can make their 3 trump tricks but you maintain control of the hand.

As you see, playing a second trump would have been disastrous.

But with a different distribution, (3-2), playing the second trump would have been great.

Considering probabilities it looks like this. If you play the second trump you will make 2 overtricks about 70% of the time, but you will go down 4 about 30% of the time.

If you stop with the ♠s and start running ♦s you will make your contract 100% of the time but will never make an overtrick.

It is tempting to just bid 3NT and hope the ♦s come in. But not when you have a 4-card Major suit. Instead you bid a Stayman 2♣. Partner says 2♠;

It is tempting to just bid 3NT and hope the ♦s come in. But not when you have a 4-card Major suit. Instead you bid a Stayman 2♣. Partner says 2♠;

Well, he has 4 ♠s. That's why you used Stayman so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by North.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♣K. Seeing 10 top tricks sort of makes you wish you had just bid 3NT.

Loser List: ♠ = 2/3/4 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 ::
Total = 2/3/4